India were from the NWFP. These include Ghaffar Khan and his brother Khan Sahib, from the Pashtun-dominated Awami National Party (ANP).[166] In Afghanistan, apart from former King Zahir Shah, Indian officials continue to idealise Najibullah and Daud Khan.[167] The common thread connecting all these leaders is their tough stand on Durand Line. India, thus, mostly engaged with leaders who had anti-Pakistan predilections. This aspect played an important role in India's decision to not engage with the Taliban. Though Pakistan was aware of the Taliban's aversion to the Durand Line, New Delhi could never accurately assess the extent to which the Taliban would be interested in challenging Islamabad. In addition to a lack of understanding of fragile Taliban-Pakistan relations, Najibullah's killing strengthened the partisans. This is reflected in India's 'strong condemnation' of the act, and hosting of Najibullah's family in India ever since.[168]

Vijay Nambiar, who had been in Kabul as ambassador in 1992, acted *in loco parentis* to Najibullah's daughters, and managed India's policy transition after the Mujahideen's rise to power, encouraged a partisan stand against the Taliban. He rejected conciliatory voices in the MEA as a crisis-induced reaction wherein some policymakers wanted to salvage the most out of the Afghan situation, and saw non-engagement with the Taliban as a 'missed opportunity' to consolidate India's presence in Afghanistan.[169] He argued that India could have tried reaching out to the Taliban, but such a contact would not have translated into a working relationship. This was because Pakistan would not have allowed the Taliban to undertake any politically, economically, or strategically consequential transaction with India.[170] This policy aspect got highlighted in a Lok Sabha debate regarding the situation in Afghanistan on 27 November 1996. Gujral, despite being a proponent of good neighbourly relations, bluntly criticised the Taliban and Pakistan:

> The pursuit of obscurantist doctrine by the Taliban leadership and the consequent denial of human rights, especially the rights of women, have been extensively condemned. The implications of these events have been assessed, especially the risk of an adverse impact on India's security.[171]

On the security aspect, Gujral highlighted India's worst fears over a Taliban-led Afghanistan.